launch attacks. Accordingly, Srijap Jamini was ordered to fall back on Srijap West while Srijap Screen, Yula II and Jamini Tilok were to fall back to Chushul. Raina issued the orders at midnight but before any of the posts could react, the Chinese opened up at 6 a.m. with artillery and mortars on all posts.

In the Srijap area, the Chinese had deployed around 300 men against each Indian picket. The Chinese held their infantry back, preferring to keep up the bombardment from artillery, direct firing RCL weapons and mortars. Under the cover of darkness, the telephone line from Dhan Singh Thapa's post to the battalion's rear headquarters at Tokung had been cut. Among the earliest casualties at Srijap West was the wireless set. After two and a half hours of relentless bombardment, the Chinese realized that Srijap Jamini had been abandoned.

The next to fall was Srijap East, as the entire section had been killed except for Rifleman Tulsi Ram. As the Chinese overran the position, they found the lone Gorkha survivor sheltering behind a rock. The 1/8 GR party at Tokung reported to Battalion and Brigade HQ that they could hear heavy firing from both the direction of Srijap and Yula. By 11 a.m. the Chinese had consolidated their position in Srijap Jamini and Srijap East, and they marched Tulsi Ram off to the Khurnak Fort.

Even though 5 Jat and 14 J&K Militia deployed in the Northern Sector had been under attack since the previous morning, Raina was very concerned about the developing situation in the Sirjap and Yula positions. Army HQ until the previous day had resisted all pleas from both Bikram Singh and Daulet Singh for additional troops, blindly repeating the Kaul mantra that the Chinese would not react and, in any case, our airlift capability to induct fresh troops was limited. That argument having collapsed, orders for the airlift of at least one Kumaoni company to Chushul were being hastened. This meant that the entire Chushul Sector, contiguous with Yula, would continue to be defended by just the one battalion, 1/8 GR minus Alpha Company, that was still in Srinagar, recuperating after being pulled out of the Galwan Valley. This effectively meant there was absolutely no scope to reinforce any post or sector if it came under attack.

After the initial two-and-a-half hour bombardment at dawn, the first attack on Dhan Singh Thapa's men at Srijap West had come at 8.30 a.m. The Gorkhas, using their relatively lighter 3-inch mortars and well positioned MMGs, halted the Chinese in their tracks, forcing them to